

# War Without Soldiers: The Robot Arms Race That Could Change Humanity Forever

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For most of human history, war carried an unavoidable political cost. Leaders who sent armies into battle also sent their nation's sons and daughters into danger. Every operation risked casualties, grieving families and pressure to bring the troops home.

But what happens when the soldiers are machines?

That question is moving rapidly from science fiction to military planning. Foundation Future Industries is developing humanoid robots for industrial and defense applications. Co-founder Sankaet Pathak has said he would be willing to arm the machines if the U.S. military requested it.

His reasoning is understandable. A robot could enter a booby-trapped building, inspect a tunnel, carry ammunition through enemy fire or clear explosives without risking a soldier's life. Machines do not become exhausted, panic under pressure or require medical evacuation. They may also permit more precise operations where the alternative would be a destructive airstrike.

And if China and Russia are pursuing weaponized robots and autonomous military systems, can America afford to stand aside?

That is the dilemma at the heart of the robot arms race. Refusing to build such systems will not stop America's adversaries. Yet the claim that robot soldiers will save lives tells only half the story.

## When War Becomes Politically Painless

The greatest danger may not be that robots rebel against humanity. It may be that they obey governments all too efficiently.

A nation might hesitate before sending 50,000 citizens into another country. It may hesitate far less before sending 50,000 machines.

There would be fewer flag-draped coffins, fewer wounded veterans and fewer military families demanding answers. The public might experience war as a distant livestream--machines fighting machines in cities far removed from ordinary life.

That could lower the political cost of military action. Technology designed to reduce casualties in one battle could make governments more willing to begin the next one.

War would no longer demand the same national sacrifice. It could become an industrial calculation: Which country has more robots, more computing power and more factories capable of replacing destroyed machines?

The result might not be fewer wars. It could be nearly continuous conflict fought at a distance by populations that barely feel its consequences.

## When Human Control Becomes Too Slow

The Pentagon requires "appropriate levels of human judgment" over autonomous weapons. That sounds reassuring, but how long will meaningful human judgment remain militarily practical?

Ukraine already offers a preview of a battlefield dominated by drones and increasingly autonomous systems. As these weapons become faster, waiting for a human commander to approve every action could become a fatal disadvantage.

An enemy swarm might identify and attack within seconds. A human supervising hundreds of machines could not examine every target individually.

The pressure will grow to give software greater freedom: let it navigate, identify suspicious movement, prioritize threats and recommend targets. Eventually, let it fire before the enemy does.

Humans may technically remain "in the loop" while exercising little more than symbolic oversight. A commander could approve the mission while algorithms make individual life-and-death decisions.

These systems will also be vulnerable to corrupted data, jammed communications, spoofed sensors and malicious software. A robot does not need to "turn evil" to become dangerous. It only needs to misidentify a civilian, follow a false signal or pursue an objective under conditions its programmers never anticipated.

Once one nation removes the human delay, every rival will face pressure to do the same. Warfare could begin moving at machine speed--too fast for humans to understand, restrain or stop.

### **An Army Without Conscience**

Human soldiers are imperfect. They can misunderstand orders, act out of fear or commit atrocities. But they also possess moral awareness. They can recognize surrender, show compassion, question an unlawful command or refuse to fire at a child.

A machine possesses none of those qualities.

It does not hate its enemy, but neither does it love its neighbor. It cannot experience cruelty, but it also cannot experience mercy. It follows software, sensor data and rules established by whoever controls it.

That could make robot soldiers the perfect instruments of tyranny.

Even brutal regimes have faced soldiers who defected, hesitated or refused to fire upon their own people. A robotic security force would have no conscience to awaken and no family among the crowd.

Scripture warns of a final system of political and economic control possessing extraordinary power over human life. Robot soldiers should not be labeled as a direct fulfillment of prophecy. Yet they could become part of the infrastructure through which a future authoritarian order enforces its will--combined with biometric identification, mass surveillance, artificial intelligence and digital control over commerce.

The question is larger than whether America should build robots before China does.

It is whether humanity is prepared for a world in which violence becomes automated, war becomes politically painless and governments possess armies that never question their commands.

Robot soldiers may save lives in tomorrow's battles. But if they also make those battles easier to begin, faster than humans can control and detached from conscience, they may change warfare in ways humanity will deeply regret.

The greatest threat is not simply that machines might one day refuse to obey us.

It is that they may obey us perfectly.

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